

back and forward buttons will take some getting used to, but ultimately, it might be a better way to navigate.

WMP 11 comes packed with a ton of features and it all looks promising. CD ripping and burning with support for encoding in the standard formats plus some new ones: Windows Media Audio Pro and WAV (lossless). As with other players, there is a tighter integration with the Web both to online stores where you can buy music as well as searching for supporting information like album art. However, it still has a way to go before supporting something like the new personal streaming feature in Winamp.

Finally, something long overdue: instantaneous search. As you type, the selection narrows down based on the entered keywords. With personal digital music libraries now running into hundreds if not thousands of songs, this feature is not a moment too soon.

Audio fingerprinting—comparing and matching song information by comparing the waveform of the song in your library against a database—is a cool new feature, but it will need to mature before it becomes truly useful.

Winamp 5.32

www.winamp.com

The world's favourite MP3 player continues to churn out great stuff... well, mostly. It is increasingly becoming harder to distinguish between media players as almost all continue to “borrow” functionality and features from each other with each new release. That said, Winamp continues to lead the pack primarily with stellar audio performance. On the video front there are still a few kinks, and on low-spec machines it tends to stagger every few minutes, so you might be more comfortable watching video on another player.

Version 5.32 introduces two new beta features: the Dashboard and Winamp Remote. Dashboard is something like a home page, and is similar to Windows Media Player's “Media Guide” page. Purportedly there are some personalisation features, but it's